MNM Fatal 2011-15

- Powered Haulage Accident
- December 8, 2011 (Minnesota)
- Crushed Stone Operation
- Crusher Operator
- 41 years old
- 9 years of experience

Overview

The victim was killed when a wheel strut axle assembly struck him. The wheel assembly was to be installed on a conveyor to transport it from the mine site. A front-end loader was used to lift the conveyor. The loader bucket suddenly dropped, allowing the frame of the conveyor to strike the wheel assembly. The wheel assembly shifted, striking the victim.

The accident occurred due to management's failure to have procedures in place to ensure equipment is taken out of service or properly repaired when defects affecting safety are found. Investigators determined the cold temperatures at the time of the accident affected the performance of the main control valve of the front-end loader's hydraulic system. Other factors contributing to the accident include the victim's position near a suspended load, no blocking in place to prevent the fall of the conveyor, and the victim not task trained regarding the installation of the wheel strut axle assembly.

Root Causes

Root Cause: Management's policies, procedures, and controls failed to effectively protect Armstrong from the suspended conveyor while he attempted to guide the wheel assembly into the conveyor strut. Suitable blocking or other effective means was not provided. Management did not task train Armstrong regarding the health and safety hazards associated with lifting/rigging a conveyor.

Corrective Action: Management established policies, procedures, and controls to ensure persons are not exposed to suspended loads when lifting conveyor components. Management trained all persons to identify hazards and eliminate them before beginning to lift conveyors.

Root Cause: Management failed to ensure any defects on equipment affecting safety be corrected in a timely manner.

Corrective Action: Management established and implemented policies, procedures, and controls requiring any defects affecting safety be corrected or the equipment removed from service.

Best Practices

- Inspect mobile equipment before placing it in operation for the shift.
- Correct safety defects on equipment in a timely manner to prevent the creation of a hazard to persons.
- Establish safe work procedures and identify and remove hazards before beginning a task.
- Ensure that persons are task-trained and understand the hazards associated with the work being performed.
- Do not place yourself in a position that will expose you to hazards while performing a task.
- Monitor personnel routinely to determine that safe work procedures are followed.